Reflexive AI

Work Group facilitation · Session 2 of 3

Reflexive AI Work Group #2

A facilitation guide for running the second session of a facilitated work group on human-centered AI in your organization, region or online.

// AIM FOR SESSION #2

Learn from the actions taken since Session 1, and turn the framework into concrete, validated action recipes for each theme.

Face-to-face, ≈3 hours

Small-group work on the themes from Session 1, informed by practitioners, ending with standardized action recipes and new actions to test before Session 3.

5–30 participants, 12 steps

Session 2 of a three-session arc. New participants are welcome and are paired with returning participants. Online is possible with breakout rooms and some modifications.

PURPOSE OF THE STUDY

Help us uncover how organizations can use AI in a human-centered manner.

A collaborative action research project run by volunteering academics and professionals, and overseen by a peer review board. Participants take part as co-researchers.

reflexiveai.org · info@reflexiveai.org

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About this guide

Thank you for contributing to the Reflexive AI research initiative. We are grateful for your time and effort.

This facilitation guide helps you run a **work group** about **reflexive AI**. Reflexivity means "*to step back and view oneself from a distance to become critically aware of oneself in relation to larger contexts*". For this initiative, it means reflecting on how your use of AI is (or is not) influenced by your values, principles and norms and how this in turn influences the people around you, your organization and broader society.

The aim for each **work group** is to meet at least three times over a period of time to contribute to the broader Reflexive AI research initiative. The work groups are based on **participatory action research**, in which scientists and professionals collaboratively and iteratively address societal challenges. The methodology is outlined here.

This guide is for **Session 2**. It takes **3 hours** and can be attended by 5–30 participants. It builds directly on the outcomes of Session 1: the selected themes, the pre-mortem posters and the actions participants committed to. Where Session 1 created a first, broad increment, Session 2 makes it **concrete**. Sub-groups translate their themes into **action recipes**: standardized descriptions of actions organizations can take to keep AI human-centered and to govern it properly.

Session roadmap

SESSION 1

- Create connections between participants.
- Clarify the aim of the initiative and how participants relate to it as co-researchers.
- Create a first, broad increment of (part of) the framework.
- Participants plan a concrete intervention they want to try within their organization before the next session.

SESSION 2 · THIS GUIDE

- Evaluate actions taken since the previous session, as well as input from the World Cafés, and use it to iterate the framework.
- Develop interventions, strategies and actions for the themes more deeply, and test those in real organizations.
- Participants plan a concrete intervention they want to try within their organization before the next session, for a segment of the framework.

SESSION 3

- Evaluate actions taken since the previous session, as well as input from the World Cafés, and use it to iterate the framework.
- Evaluate the process and outcomes to date (a "reality check") and identify open questions, challenges and dilemmas.
- Participants can then choose to continue with more sessions or to stop; other work groups can pick up the open questions.

The above is an outline. The aim of Session 3 may be adjusted based on group preferences.

Contributing to the Reflexive AI initiative

We designed this guide for work groups that contribute to our global research initiative. This is not required — you can run this work group within your organization in isolation. If you do contribute to the research initiative, please ensure:

- That you **coordinate with our team** at reflexiveai.org so we can ensure academic rigor, pre- and post-session surveys, and informed consent by all participants. We publish outcomes and materials on GitHub.
- That **all participants are aware they are participating in a research initiative**, and that the (anonymous) results from the discussions will be shared with other work groups and on GitHub.
- That **new participants** who did not attend Session 1 fill in the informed consent form before they take part.
- That you do **not bias participants** by pushing them in a certain direction (e.g. "AI is great" or "AI is terrible").
- That you do **not modify the format** unless absolutely necessary. Informed consent must always take place at the start. If you require deviations, please let us know what you changed and how.

Please contact us at info@reflexiveai.org with questions.

How to prepare

Several days before the session

- Send a pre-workshop email that includes:
  - A note that Session 2 focuses on deepening the ideas from Session 1. This will be hard work, but we will use facilitation techniques to help us think.
  - A link to the pre-workshop survey, which is helpful for participants to prepare.
  - A request to bring a laptop if they want to draw inspiration from external resources (e.g. data, GitHub, AI).
  - A request for participants who were unable to attend the first session to pick the selected theme that best fits their expertise, so they can join that group. If no theme matches, an extra station can be set up.
- Invite **up to four participants for the User Experience Fishbowl** (Step 4). Look for people with personal experience of governance, governance actions and governance frameworks, and of what makes them successful. Brief them on the format and the questions they will discuss. Their conversation helps the sub-groups identify which kinds of actions and interventions to focus on.
- Collect the data from the **World Cafés**. The sub-groups use it to validate their action recipes in Step 9.

Materials

- Materials from Session 1:
  - The filled-in pre-mortem posters for each theme, including stickies.
  - The filled-in poster for the definition of human-centered AI.
  - The filled-in 15% Solutions poster with the actions participants chose to implement before session 2.
  - Printed sheets of the research presentation from Step 5 of Session 1, including the slide with the sixteen starting themes.
  - The study roadmap and the Purpose-to-Practice Worksheet.
  - The helpful resources poster and the give & get help poster.
- Print a fresh 15% Solutions poster (1 total) for the actions planned in this session.
- Print the action recipe on A1-2 size, **5 per expected sub-group**.
- Print the question storming poster on A1 size, **1 per sub-group**, to capture the questions that should be answered for a theme.
- Print the informed consent forms for new participants (bring a few spares).
- Print summaries of the relevant World Café data (PDFs) and expert interviews (PDF), at least one set per sub-group.
- A stack of empty flip charts or whiteboards.
- Bring stickies, markers and pens.
- Laptops or phones, if participants want to use AI to help draft action recipes.
- A timer is useful to track time.
- A buzzer or tingsha bell is useful to indicate new rounds.
- Optionally, bring snacks and drinks for a relaxed atmosphere.

Setting up the room

- Populate the room beforehand. Create as many stations as in Session 1, plus one extra in case another theme is picked up.
- Put up the **pre-mortem poster** of each theme, with the stickies from last time, at its station.
- Put up the other materials from Session 1: the definition of human-centered AI, the 15% Solutions poster, the dot votes and printed sheets of the research presentation. These act as external memory and as stigmergic traces of the previous session.
- Put up a **question storming poster** and a stack of action recipes at each station.

15 min

Step 1. Welcome and refresher

We welcome participants and use the materials from Session 1 as external memory. “Walking the walls” refreshes insights for returning participants and lets new participants catch up quickly, guided by someone who was there. This exercise is a way to highlight stigmergic traces that facilitate self-organization.

Steps

- **Welcome** people as they arrive. Ensure **new participants** fill in the **informed consent form** before they join the exercise.
- Welcome everyone and introduce yourself briefly. A more thorough opening follows after this exercise, but we want to break the ice and set the interactive tone immediately. Ask participants to form pairs, self-organizing so that each new participant is paired with at least one participant who attended Session 1.
- **10 min** Pairs walk around the room, in whatever order works for them, to refresh the insights and materials from the previous session: the pre-mortem posters, the definition of human-centered AI, the 15% Solutions and the research presentation sheets.
- **5 min** Debrief by collecting a few insights. Encourage the participants to use open questions, observations and uncertainties to guide what they do in the coming steps.

5 min

Step 2. Opening

We open the second work group session.

1. **Thank** the participants for returning, and welcome new participants.
2. **Reiterate informed consent**: participants take part in a research initiative, and the anonymous results will be shared with other work groups and on GitHub. Explain that **overview pictures (not close-ups)** may be taken of the activities to share on social media, and note that anyone who prefers not to be in any pictures can approach the facilitators at a suitable time.
3. **Clarify the aim** of this session: to learn from the actions taken since Session 1, and to make our ideas more concrete by translating each theme into action recipes that organizations can use.
4. **Set expectations** that this is harder than Session 1, because we move from broad ideas to concrete actions. That is why we will hear from people with experience in governance first.

15 min

Step 3. Evaluate actions with Impromptu Networking

In action research, taking action generates the feedback that informs the next iteration. In pairs, participants evaluate the actions they took since Session 1. New participants, or participants who did not take action, ask clarifying questions and share related experiences.

Steps

- **4 min** Ask participants to form pairs. Ask: *"What action did you take since the last session? What happened? What worked or did not work?"*
- **4 min** Ask participants to form new pairs. The pairs respond to the same prompt and also look for patterns across conversations.
- **4 min** Ask participants to form new pairs once more. The pairs respond to the same prompt and also look for patterns across conversations.
- **3 min** Shared debrief with the whole group. Which themes and patterns did people notice across the conversations? How does this inform the actions we develop today?

25 min

Step 4. Learn from experience with a User Experience Fishbowl

Making the governance framework concrete requires an understanding of what governance can look like in practice. Up to four participants with experience in governance take the center of the fishbowl, along with a facilitator, and share what governance entails, what it requires and what makes it successful. Their conversation inspires the sub-groups and helps them identify which kinds of actions and interventions to focus on.

Steps

- Arrange the chairs: an inner circle for the guests and the facilitator, and an outer circle seated as close to the inner circle as possible.
- **10 min** The inner circle discusses their insights, guided by the facilitator: *"What does good governance look like in practice? What does it require? What makes governance interventions and frameworks succeed or fail?"* The facilitator can ask clarifying questions to make abstract ideas concrete (e.g. "What did that look like in your case?" or "What is a real-life example of that?"). The outer circle listens.
- **5 min** The outer circle forms small groups and generates questions they would like the inner circle to answer. Questions are written on **stickies** and passed to the facilitator.
- **10 min** The inner circle discusses answers to the questions. The facilitator clusters similar questions to make the most of the time.

5 min

Step 5. Return to the theme stations

The sub-groups from Session 1 reconvene at their stations. This is also a moment to re-organize.

Steps

- Point out the stations for the themes selected in Session 1.
- Give participants the opportunity to **switch sub-groups** if they want to. New participants pick the theme that best suits their expertise and interest.
- If some people have a strong desire to pick up **another theme** that was not selected in Session 1, they can do so. They take an empty station and use the theme definition from the research presentation as a starting point.
- Check that sub-groups are of a workable size, ideally 3–5 people each.

20 min

Step 6. Question storming with 1-2-4-ALL

Governance is all about avoiding harmful, damaging outcomes. Before generating actions, it helps to know which questions should be addressed for a theme. We use 1-2-4-ALL within each sub-group to first generate questions rather than answers (question storming).

Steps

- Set the stage. Explain that the aim is to generate questions, not answers. Encourage participants to draw on their pre-mortem poster and the fishbowl conversation.
- **2 min** Ask participants to reflect silently and individually on: *"For our theme, what questions should an organization answer to keep AI human-centered and prevent harmful outcomes?"* Invite them to **write down** their questions on **stickies**.
- **4 min** Ask participants to pair up within their sub-group, exchange questions, and build on each other's questions.
- **8 min** Pairs join to form groups of four (or the whole sub-group, if smaller). They compare and combine their questions, and identify their top three questions in terms of importance and impact.
- **6 min** Each sub-group captures its questions on the **question storming poster**. If there are more than three questions, groups pick the top three out of those present. Ask one or two sub-groups to share a striking question with the whole room.
- **collect** Pictures of the filled-in question storming posters.

30 min

Step 7. Generate action recipes (part 1)

The sub-groups now generate actions to keep AI human-centered for their theme, and to govern it properly. Encourage participants to generate actions they feel would be useful in their organization while also being potentially relevant to others. The questions from the previous step, the actions already identified on the pre-mortem poster and the fishbowl conversation provide input. Participants can also find inspiration for actions in the World Café data (Station 4), where other groups and organiations identified strategies relevant to them.

To provide structure, each action is captured on an **action recipe template**. Its guiding questions make the action concrete, and ensure all actions are presented in a standardized fashion so they can be compared, combined and published as part of the framework.

Steps

- Explain the action recipe template and its guiding questions. Hand out the templates to each station.
- **30 min** The sub-groups work to generate a couple of concrete actions, using the action recipe template to guide them. They can expand ideas already generated in Session 1, draw from the fishbowl conversation or develop actions to address questions from the question storming. Participants can use AI to help them, for example to explore options or sharpen a draft, but the sub-group decides what goes on the template. Aim for quality over quantity.

20 min

Step 8. Shift & Share

Before continuing with another 30-minute timebox to generate and validate action recipes, participants now tour the other stations to give feedback, draw inspiration and notice patterns across themes with Shift & Share.

Steps

- Explain the sequence of steps.
- Each sub-group picks one **host**. This person stays at the station throughout the exercise and talks visitors through the action recipes. If you run this work group with fewer than 8 participants, you can also tour the stations as a whole group.
- **5 min** The sub-groups — except the host — move clockwise to the next station. The host presents the action recipes; visitors give feedback and add ideas on **stickies** attached to the templates.
- **15 min** Repeat three more times, or as often as time allows. Encourage participants to note patterns they see across stations.

30 min

Step 9. Refine and validate action recipes (part 2)

The sub-groups return to their stations. They first use the feedback and inspiration from Shift & Share to refine action recipes or generate more. Next, the focus shifts to **validation**: testing the actions against the pre-mortem failure scenarios from Session 1. The step closes with a short debrief.

Steps

- **15 min** The host shares the feedback received. The sub-group improves its existing action recipes and generates new ones.
- **10 min** Shift the focus to validation. The sub-group tests each action recipe against its pre-mortem poster: *"Would this action have prevented the failure scenarios we imagined? Which scenarios are not yet covered? What can be improved in our actions?"*. The World Café data provides another source for validation, particularly Station 3 where other groups and organizations provided scenarios where AI was/is not sufficiently human-centered for them. Update the action recipes.
- **5 min** Bring everyone together and ask: *"What was it like to generate action recipes? What did you notice? What was more difficult or easier than expected?"* The facilitators take notes.
- **collect** Pictures/scans of the filled-in action recipes.
- **collect** Pictures of the updated pre-mortem posters.
- **collect** Pictures of facilitator notes.

15 min

Step 10. Identify actions with 15% Solutions

Action research aims to implement solutions to real-world challenges. We use the Liberating Structure 15% Solutions to help participants pick an intervention to test before Session 3. The action recipes created today are a natural starting point: by trying one in their own organization, at a scale that is manageable (e.g. work group, team, department, organization), participants generate the feedback that will inform the next iteration of the framework.

Steps

- **4 min** Ask participants to silently and individually reflect on: *"Based on the action recipes we created today, what is an intervention you can implement within your organization to test, develop or deepen the framework before the next session? What is within your mandate and available resources?"*
- **6 min** Invite people to form pairs to share their actions and coach each other to make them more concrete and doable. Capture actions on **index cards** or **stickies**, noting which action recipe they relate to.
- **5 min** Ask participants who feel comfortable to share their actions. Put the stickies on the 15% Solutions poster.
- **collect** The 15% Solutions poster with actions.

Step 11. What's next?

Close the session by thanking everyone for their time. If this group participates in the research initiative, reiterate that the anonymous results will be shared with the initiative, and that research updates will be available on reflexiveai.org. Provide a brief preview of Session 3: we evaluate the actions taken, iterate the framework again, and reflect on the outcomes and the process to achieve them.

We recommend going through this checklist:

- **collect** Filled-in informed consent forms for every new participant.
- **collect** The filled-in action recipes, including stickies with feedback.
- **collect** The updated pre-mortem posters.
- **collect** The filled-in question storming posters.
- **collect** The 15% Solutions poster, the fishbowl questions and pictures of the flip charts. Keep all posters for Session 3, where they act as "external memory" again.

Step 12. Share the results

When you've completed the session, please share the following with the research initiative if you opted to do so.

- Clear pictures or scans of the action recipes and posters, including any stickies or content on them. Please remove or blur people's names and company-sensitive information. These will be published on our public GitHub to benefit the initiative and other work groups.
- A brief review by you and any other facilitators of how the session went. What worked? What did not? Where did you observe tension or friction?
- Scans or pictures of filled-in informed consent forms for all new participants. Unfortunately, we cannot process *any* data without informed consent.
- Send the materials to info@reflexiveai.org.

Post-session activities

After the session, facilitators individually capture their experiences, observations and reflections in a personal log. The aim is to document what was noticed — surprises, tensions, assumptions and emerging questions — and how this informs the next session.

If the sessions contribute to the research initiative, a short follow-up survey will be sent to the participants' email addresses.